

DVD). So all you need is a system with a DVD drive to enjoy the test suite.

Installing it is very easy and you can do so by using your system repositories or the executables provided at the project website. PTS actually acts as a wrapper for many open source/proprietary software that are available off-the-shelf.

By default, PTS doesn't come with a single benchmarking utility installed; rather, it provides an option to install them the way you want. In order to get the most out of PTS, you have to install the tests, one by one. Some tests are as huge as 700 MB, and thus installation can be a bother. It would be much better if Phoronix additionally allowed users to install multiple tests in a single click, with options like 'Tests for Processors', 'Tests for the GPU', and so on. The pack must consist of a handful of relevant tests that fall under the particular category the user is interested in.

Phoronix allows users to easily upload their results to Phoronix Global. This is a portal where you can view your results (the same way you view them offline), and from where you can make comparisons with others. In fact, the application itself prompts you to compare the result with the tests that Phoronix developers have uploaded. A very nice approach that does away with the hassle of searching for the test results to compare with your outcome.

Phoronix also provides a small system 'overview' that keeps you informed about hardware, software and sensors. Things are very neatly arranged in their proper categories. It even allows you to copy all the data to clipboards and then share them easily. However, in my case, it failed to detect the IGP (on-board graphics) speed. The system memory usage data was displayed incorrectly as well.

The downside of PTS is that there is no notification whatsoever while installing and running tests. Once you initiate the process, the PTS window will vanish and the user has no idea of what's happening in the background. Even though it was mentioned that support with Ubuntu notification has been added, it didn't work in Ubuntu 9.04 64-bit. Instead, a simple status message on the PTS window should have sufficed.

Geekbench

Geekbench is another efficient benchmarking software for Linux. Despite claiming to be cross-platform software, it only provides a GUI for Windows and Mac, leaving Linux

with a CLI offering. Nonetheless, the application offers a complete benchmarking solution capable of wrenching the most out of your CPU and memory.

The Linux version is an easy to execute binary file that runs from the terminal. After executing it, the benchmarking will commence and automatically complete all the tests. In the end, it will ask you to submit the data, online. If you have a working Internet connection, you can easily submit the data and add it to your profile (if you have an account). Pretty nifty indeed!

The online score browser displays scores in coloured charts—this is where you can compare your scores as well. Unlike other benchmarking software, this one gives an overall score to the system providing a rough idea of what the system is capable of.

Compared to the other two benchmarking utilities mentioned, Geekbench is not an open source application, although the developers have open sourced the detection engine (geekinfo) under the MIT licence. The detection engine seems to be flaky—it failed to detect my motherboard manufacturer and model. Apart from that, it failed to even detect the operating system used. It only showed the kernel under use instead of the distro. Since Geekbench developers want you to buy the software, they have restricted the availability of the 64-bit executable.

One of the biggest drawbacks was the overall inconsistency in scores. I tested Geekbench in all the supported OSs, namely OSX, Windows and several distributions, keeping the hardware intact across every OS. Initially developed for Mac OS, Geekbench still favours that OS by delivering the highest scores on it. The claims of providing an OS-neutral benchmarking engine seem hollow, and the statements are contradictory to the scores.

Benefits of benchmarking

Many of you must be muttering about all this information on benchmarking. Why waste resources? Why go through such trouble and waste time just for a few numbers? Well, because benchmarking is the easiest way to gauge your system. Today, all system components—be it the CPU, memory, hard drive, graphics adapters, power supply, etc.—are thoroughly benchmarked and tested, and then, accordingly, manufacturers rank them by price and performance.

Benchmarking creates a sense of judgement among users. It keeps you updated about the potential of

TechnoMail - Enterprise Email Server
Anti SPAM, Anti Virus, Email Content Filtering

Firewall, Internet Access Control
Content Filtering, Site Blocking

Bandwidth Management System

Managed Email Hosting Solutions

TechnoInfotech®

1, Vikas Permisses, 11 Bank Street, Fort, Mumbai, India - 400 001. Tel.: 91-22-6633 8900 Ext. 324. info@technoinfotech.com